No evidence suggests the US gave the Musharraf regime any guarantees with regards to the Kashmir jihad at the time. However, the cooperation Pakistan agreed to provide did not include action against those militants focused on fighting in Indian-administered Kashmir or attacking India, save to keep them from traveling to Afghanistan to support the Taliban.[8] America's focus in the nearterm was on al-Qaeda and the Taliban, unless the latter agreed to hand over bin Laden and his associates. Musharraf claimed to have saved the Kashmir jihad from American interference and signaled that it would continue.[9] The Pakistani government distinguished the so-called freedom fighters of Kashmir from al-Qaeda and other foreign elements.[10] Although US President George W. Bush drew a rhetorical line in the sand between those who were with America and those aligned with al-Qaeda, the US did not immediately demand that Pakistan dismantle the militant groups it had nurtured. This was despite the fact that some of the same groups the Musharraf regime was protecting were deploying their fighters to battle US forces. Complicating matters was the fact that although the ISI had been directed to quit Afghanistan after 9/11, some of its officers also remained there to fight alongside the Taliban and the Pakistani jihadis allied with it.[11]

Lashkar's primary focus was Indian-administered Kashmir, and so Musharraf's decision to protect that front aligned with the group's priorities. The group also had no particular loyalty to the Taliban government or interests in Afghanistan. But, as detailed in the previous chapter, it did have significant interests in Pakistan that could be used as leverage against it. This contrasted with the Deobandi outfits, which had significant interests in Afghanistan and enjoyed robust relations with the Taliban. However, the US counter-attack understandably angered Lashkar's leaders and cadres, leading to debates within the group over how to respond. Before examining Lashkar's response in greater detail, it is helpful to explore its pre-9/11 experiences in Afghanistan relative to the Deobandi groups, since this contributed to how these actors responded in the wake of al-Qaeda's attacks against America.

Late in the autumn of 1991 the government of Pakistan began pressuring foreign fighters to leave the region, leading many of the Arab fighters who had come to wage jihad against Afghanistan to disperse. The degeneration of the Afghan jihad against the Soviets into infighting among the various